

Product: Product Development Lifecycle (PDLC) Roadmap

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Department: Product & Design

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1. Overview

The Product Development Lifecycle (PDLC) is our standardized framework for taking ideas from concept to production. Every feature, regardless of size, must follow these stages to ensure quality, security, and user alignment.

2. The Five Phases of the PDLC

Phase 1: Discovery & Ideation

- **Goal:** Identify a user problem and validate the potential solution.
- **Key Output:** Opportunity Assessment.
- **Stakeholders:** Product Manager (PM), Design Lead, User Research.

Phase 2: Definition & Requirements

- **Goal:** Define "what" we are building and "why."
- **Key Output:** Product Requirements Document (PRD).
- **Requirements:** Must include User Stories, Acceptance Criteria, and success metrics (KPIs).
- **Engineering Sync:** PMs must review the draft PRD with Engineering Leads to assess technical feasibility.

Phase 3: Design & Prototyping

- **Goal:** Visualize the solution and test usability.
- **Key Output:** High-fidelity Figma Mockups & Prototypes.
- **Design Review:** All designs must be reviewed for accessibility (WCAG 2.1 compliance) and consistency with the company Design System.

Phase 4: Development & QA

- **Goal:** Build and test the feature.
- **Workflow:** Following the Engineering Monorepo standards.

- **Testing:** Requires unit tests, integration tests, and a manual QA sign-off in the Staging environment.
- **Security Check:** Any feature handling PII (Personally Identifiable Information) must undergo a Security Review as per the *Data Security Protocol*.

Phase 5: Launch & Iteration

- **Goal:** Release to users and measure impact.
- **Release Strategy:** We prefer "Dark Launches" (feature flags) to roll out to 5%, 25%, and then 100% of users.
- **Post-Launch:** PMs must conduct a "Impact Analysis" 30 days post-launch to compare results against the KPIs defined in Phase 2.

3. Product Documentation Standards

All product documents must be stored in the centralized **Product Wiki**. A standard PRD must contain:

1. **Context:** The "Problem Statement."
2. **Goals:** What success looks like.
3. **User Flows:** Diagrams showing the user's journey.
4. **Functional Specs:** Detailed technical requirements.
5. **Analytics:** Tracking events to be implemented.

4. Feature Request Process

Non-product employees (Sales, Support, HR) who wish to suggest a feature should not message PMs directly. Instead:

1. Submit a request via the **Product Portal**.
2. The Product Team reviews requests during the "Monthly Backlog Grooming" session.
3. Status updates (Under Review, Planned, Declined) are pushed automatically to the #product-roadmap Slack channel.

Note to AI Assistant:

If a user asks "How do I build a new feature?" or "What is a PRD?":

1. Summarize the 5 phases of the PDLC.
2. Mention that the PM is the primary owner of the PRD.
3. Direct them to Phase 4 for information on the technical "Data Security Protocol" if they are an engineer.